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Grocery Coupon & Cashback Stacking Guide

A free beginner's guide to paying less at the register: store apps, coupons and cashback.

Savings depend on your store, what you buy, and current offers. Offers change often and can end at any time. Nothing here is a promise of savings or money. Always check each app's and store's current terms.

What "stacking" means

Stacking means using **more than one kind of savings on the same purchase**, where the store's rules allow it. For groceries there are four layers:

1. **The sale price.** Start with an item that is already on sale (store flyer or app).
2. **A store digital coupon.** Free in the store's app. You "clip" it, then it applies when you check out with your phone number or loyalty card.
3. **A manufacturer coupon.** From the brand (printed, in a flyer, or in an app). Many stores accept them. Policies differ.
4. **A cashback offer.** An app gives you money back after you buy and verify (usually with a receipt scan). This is separate from the register.

Not every store allows every layer. Some stores don't take manufacturer coupons. Some limit how many you can use. Read the store's coupon policy (usually on its website) or ask at customer service.

Step 1: Set up (about 20 minutes, one time)

1. **Download your main store's app** (the one you shop at most). Sign up with your phone number or loyalty card.
2. **Find the "Coupons" or "Deals" tab.** Look for digital coupons.
3. **Add one cashback app** to start (examples: Ibotta, Fetch). Don't install five apps at once. Learn one first.
4. **Keep your receipts** (paper or photo) until your cashback is approved.

Privacy note: cashback and rewards apps collect data about what you buy. Read what they collect. Only share

what you are comfortable with. Don't pay anyone to "unlock" coupons. Real coupon apps are free.

Step 2: Shop in this order

Before the trip

1. Open the store's weekly ad (in the app or online).
2. Write your list. Put sale items first.
3. In the store's app, **clip digital coupons** for items on your list.
4. In your cashback app, **check for offers** on items on your list. Add them *before* you shop. Many offers must be added first to count.

In the store

5. Buy the exact product and size listed in the coupon or offer. A different size may not qualify.
6. Compare the unit price. A coupon on a pricey brand may still cost more than the store brand.

At checkout

7. Use your phone number or loyalty card so the digital coupons apply.
8. Check your receipt before you leave. If a coupon didn't apply, ask the cashier right away.

After you shop

9. Scan your receipt in the cashback app (if the offer requires it). Do it soon, because offers and receipt windows can expire.

A stacking example (EXAMPLE only, not real prices)

This is made-up math to show how the layers work. Your real prices will be different.

Layer	EXAMPLE
Regular price of cereal	$4.00
On sale this week	$3.00
Store digital coupon	−$0.50
Manufacturer coupon (if the store allows)	−$0.50
At the register	**$2.00**
Cashback offer after scanning the receipt	−$0.50 (back in the app)
Net cost	**$1.50**

Check: many stores don't allow stacking a store coupon and a manufacturer coupon on the same item. Ask first.

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7 beginner rules

1. **Only buy what you will use.** A coupon on something you don't need is not a saving.
2. **Match the sale and the coupon.** The best deal is a sale item plus a coupon.
3. **Read the fine print:** product, size, limit per transaction, expiration date.
4. **Don't buy extras to reach a coupon minimum** unless you were going to buy them anyway.
5. **Never use a coupon that doesn't match your item.** That is coupon fraud. It can get you banned and is illegal in some cases.
6. **Never print or share fake coupons.** If a "coupon" looks too good to be true, skip it.
7. **Stockpile carefully.** Only for things that keep and that you use (pasta, canned beans, rice, toothpaste).

Common mistakes

- Forgetting to clip the digital coupon *before* checkout.

- Using a different phone number than your store account.
- Buying the wrong size or variety.
- Missing the cashback expiration date.
- Signing up for many apps and using none of them.
- Spending money to save money.

How to check if it's worth your time

For two shopping trips, write down:

	Trip 1	Trip 2
Total before coupons	$	$
Total at the register	$	$
Cashback pending in app	$	$
Minutes spent on coupons and scanning		

If the time doesn't feel worth it, keep only the easiest step (usually the store's digital coupons).

Quick checklist

- [ ] Store app installed, signed in with my phone number
- [ ] Weekly ad checked
- [ ] Digital coupons clipped for my list
- [ ] Cashback offers added *before* the trip
- [ ] Right product and size
- [ ] Receipt checked at the register
- [ ] Receipt scanned in the cashback app

Made for the community. Share it with a friend who is watching their budget.